also chose to show themselves at the jharoka of the Qila-e-Mualla (Red Fort) in Delhi, built by the grandson of Akbar.

At some point in his busy morning Akbar would have found time to visit his beloved pigeon cotes. Mullazada Mulla Asamudin Ibrahim would have found some consolation for his abrupt termination as first tutor to Akbar had he seen the lifelong obsession that Akbar had for pigeon flying, which he called ishq-baazi. There were 20,000 pigeons in the imperial household, of which 500 were khasa, or special. The most valued pigeon in this fluttering ensemble was called Mohan, and belonged to Aziz Koka. They were kept in pigeon cotes made of blue and white bricks and were cared for by eunuchs and maidservants. Some of the pigeons were used to deliver messages while others were kept for the beauty and magnificence of their iridescent plumage. A few extra-special ones were trained to perform intricate manoeuvres and acrobatics while flying, which astounded the visitors to court. ‘It will seem little short of miraculous,’ wrote Monserrate, overcome, ‘when I affirm that when sent out, they dance, turn somersaults all together in the air, fly in orderly rhythm and return to their starting point, all at the sound of a whistle.’ One hundred and one pigeons were let out at a time to perform these various skills, a blur of pearl-grey synchronicity.

At some point in his day Akbar would make time to inspect his special animals. ‘He knew the names of all his elephants, though he had many thousands of them’, wrote du Jarric, ‘of his pigeons, his deer, and the other wild animals which he kept in his parks, and of all his horses to which names had been given. Each day, a certain number of these animals were brought before him for his inspection. He watched these from his window; and as each animal passed him, its name and that of the person responsible for feeding it was read out to him.’ The attendants were rewarded if the animals were thriving, if they were not their salary was docked.

Both Agra and Fatehpur Sikri were now populous and thriving cities. The road between the two cities was made up of a market so full of produce and people that it looked like one continuous town. Fine bullock-carts, carved and gilded with gold and covered with silks and fine cloths, trundled on the road ferrying people and goods between the cities. There were merchants from Persia and Hindustan, trading in silks and precious stones like rubies, diamonds, and pearls. Many of these merchants and traders would have been serving the important courtiers of the city.